📝 Notes

Jan 29, 2026

Spkassociates Workflow/Customization Review

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Attachments Spkassociates Workflow/Customization Review

Meeting records Transcript File

Summary

Method Junction discussed the workflow and business model of SPK Associates, emphasizing their commission-based compensation, their use of "Opportunities" for sales management, and the critical need to prevent direct communication between vendors and customers, as highlighted by Don. A major talking point was the complex, custom Request for Quotes (RFQS) and Purchase Order (PO) process, which uses a Vendor Portal with a messaging board to manage vendor communication and tracking. Method Junction is developing a custom ChatGBT integration via Google Sheets and Zapier for SPK Associates to streamline the sales process and eliminate manual data entry. Method Junction also reviewed the simpler workflow of GT Simulators, noting their complex invoicing for inventory and prepayment, alongside frequently requested customizations such as color-coding and the ability to create multiple POs from a single Sales Order screen.

Details

- **Client Workflow and Business Model for SPK Associates** Method Junction is seeking to understand the workflow and personas for the specific account, SPK

Associates, an MWD account, and any others worked with (00:00:00). SPK Associates bridges the gap between vendors and customers; a critical aspect of their business is ensuring vendors and customers cannot communicate directly to prevent customers from bypassing SPK Associates for better deals with the vendor (00:01:12). Don, the primary contact who manages the company, emphasized this separation (00:02:31).

- **Compensation Structure for SPK Associates** The company utilizes a commission-based system, similar to professional services, where representatives start with a salary they must "pay off" through sales (00:02:31). Once representatives improve at their job, they transition away from a salary to a compensation model based solely on sales. This structure is managed using a commissions app (00:03:26).
- **SPK Associates' Workflow Management** SPK Associates manages its sales pipeline through "Opportunities," which is where all new leads and business enter (00:03:26). This approach differs from many construction/storage clients who prefer "Estimates," because SPK Associates manages multiple types of documents such as purchase orders, sales orders, estimates, and invoices, often multiple times per job (e.g., one chair to five chairs) (00:04:28). Method Junction explained that Opportunities are better suited for managing the sales pipeline and holding comprehensive information for custom work, which includes vendor lists, scope of work, and various dates (00:05:29).
- **Request for Quotes (RFQS) Process** SPK Associates utilizes Request for Quotes (RFQS), a custom app critical for manufacturing workflows that differs from a standard estimate (00:07:27). The RFQS process focuses on gathering material and design details from the customer rather than initial pricing, which comes later (00:08:32). The customer provides their specifications to SPK Associates (e.g., "I want a chair. This is what I want in my chair"). After the RFQS is built, it can be converted to a Purchase Order (PO) to be sent to the vendor (00:09:26).
- **Vendor and Customer Relationship Management** SPK Associates serves customers by offering manufacturing expertise and connections to wholesalers, while they help vendors gain customers that fit their specific needs (00:10:19). The pricing system is primarily custom, but Method Junction recommended implementing pricing levels, as the current commission tiers based on products sold suggest a similar multiplier system is already in use, although calculated manually by the sales representatives (00:11:14).

- **Quote Worksheet and Design Process** After vendors return with pricing information via the Purchase Order, a "Quote Worksheet" is generated for the customer, essentially serving as a finalized estimate for approval (00:13:01). This process includes a design breakdown and instructions on how items should be built, which is then included with the RFQS to specify desired designs (00:13:52).
- **Managing Purchase Orders and Vendor Communication** When converting a Request for Quote to a Purchase Order, the system generates distinct POs for multiple vendors assigned to the items, accommodating scenarios where five items and four vendors result in four separate POs (00:14:57). Vendor communication is critical, and SPK Associates uses a Vendor Portal with a messaging board to avoid excessive emailing and track communication. The portal allows vendors to fill in crucial details, like pallet information for shipping, which significantly reduces back-and-forth communication (00:17:54) (00:21:07).
- **Inventory and Shipping Considerations** SPK Associates generally operates with non-inventory items that come in and go out immediately (00:16:55). For shipping, they outsource to a third party and manually input the tracking number (00:19:11). Method Junction acknowledged that for many clients, starting with a manual process (e.g., tracking number input) is necessary to build confidence before moving toward automation, such as API integrations (00:20:12). However, ShipStation is a highly recommended, pre-connected API solution for shipping, although SPK Associates is not ready for that yet (00:25:02).
- **SPK Associates User Engagement and Roles** Out of seven users, five to six people actively use the system, with one primarily dedicated to reporting (00:27:20). Method Junction inferred from user session data that different users focus on different parts of the process, such as one potentially dedicated to outsourcing and shipping. It is suspected that sales representatives handle their accounts end-to-end, managing contacts and proposals (00:29:17).
- **Custom Integration for Sales Efficiency** Method Junction is developing a custom ChatGBT integration using Google Sheets and Zapier to streamline the sales process for SPK Associates (00:31:40). This integration aims to allow sales representatives to verbally have a conversation with ChatGBT, which then fills out an importable Google Sheet for creating an Opportunity in Method, thereby eliminating manual data entry into the system multiple times. This is considered a "game changer" because it removes repetition and typing, making the process much easier for the sales team (00:32:31).

- **GT Simulators Workflow and Customization** The workflow for GT Simulators, a medical manufacturing client, is simpler, managing requests and sales primarily through Sales Orders and a prepayment/Net 30 system. This flow starts with an Estimate, which, once accepted, moves to a Sales Order (00:23:04). Their system uses HTML customizations to track shipment status visually (yellow for partially shipped, green for fulfilled) (00:40:07). Method Junction noted that Sales Orders are the most customized application across their accounts as they serve as the project management tool for shipments (00:43:37).
- **Challenges with Inventory and Invoicing** For GT Simulators' prepayment model, a complex invoicing method is required to accurately update inventory: the initial prepayment invoice is updated to reflect items shipped, ensuring the total payment amount remains constant while inventory is tracked live (00:40:07). A significant challenge is ensuring the "Invoiced" column updates live, particularly with partial shipping, which is a common occurrence (00:41:59).
- **Key Customization Requests** Method Junction highlighted several frequently requested customizations, including the ability to color-code records in the grid view (although this currently requires extensive HTML customization) (00:45:32). Other major requests are enabling the live updating of the invoice column to reflect changes and allowing for the creation of multiple Purchase Orders for different vendors from a single Sales Order screen, which is currently a complex, multi-step manual process (00:46:21). Method Junction noted that only four out of 22 accounts use Purchase Orders, but all require customization on the screen used for creating POs (00:48:17).

Suggested next steps

- [ ] Method Junction will ask Ryan about why they used the quote worksheet in particular and then provide a better answer.
- [ ] Method Junction will ask the SPK Associates client whether the salespeople also handle the invoicing and confirm the exact number of people involved in the process.

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Method Junction: So many buttons. Okay. Okay. So, what we're really trying to understand here is to understand a little bit of the workflow as well as um a little bit of the people that you're building this for um to understand some of your general personas. Um and this is while we're focusing on one specific account. Um if you could speak to any of the other additional MWD accounts that you've worked with as well, that'd be very helpful. And there's also no wrong answers like Yeah. Yeah. I got you. Yeah. Um, okay. Do you want me to share my screen? Yeah, it'd be great if you could walk through um the workflow that you built for SDK Associates. That'd be great. So, just so you know, I only got this account like a week, not a week, like few months ago. Okay. But I have I shared it all with John as well to have all like the historical stuff that Cole and Ryan did.

00:01:12

Method Junction: Yeah. Um, so I want to do one thing as well. So for how let me get this. You can just exit. Okay. Um, all right. So the biggest things is they have two aspects of their business and as like an engineer who worked in this too because uh the biggest thing is that it's like there has to separate I guess I'll wait for but um they have to separate who they talk to and how they talk to and what I mean by that hey Barbara is that the vendors can't know their customers like that's like a huge And the reason why and thinking about it, it makes more sense is that for them, this is like in particular them, but again, it's for like a lot of places where it's that they're bridging the gap between these two sides to say like, okay, hey, you're going to come to me, you want a chair. I'm like, okay, sweet. I'm really good at the design process and building that, but I don't build chairs.

00:02:31

Method Junction: So, let me connect you to my chair guy. And then that's kind of like their vendors are like finding connecting those people. But then again, if the customer found out the vendor, why am I going to talk to SPK anymore? I'm just going to go talk to the chair guy and get a better deal. Yeah. So like that's like a big like that was like the first thing when I talked to him that was the first thing he said whenever we do anything they cannot talk to each other, see each other, know each other, who they are. Like that was the thing that he really hammered home. Yeah. And that's Don, like my primary contact, who I believe is like pretty much runs the company. Yeah. Um, and then after that, it's very much like a commissionbased system. So, as the reps sell, um, they start off as saying it's similar to kind of professional services in the in the way of they get a salary and they have to like pay off their salary.

00:03:26

Method Junction: So like that's we have like a commissions app to manage that and then as they get better at the job. So like when we start as juniors you have obviously like a lower salary and like bigger bonus to like make up. But then what how they do it it's like you pay off your salary pretty much until like not actually but like figuratively until you're they're like okay you're good enough. You don't need a salary anymore. You just sell. Okay. So that's the that business part. Then their workflow is very much in opportunities. So they start in opportunities and this is where all the leads come in. Anyone that's like any new business, they always go here. So for a lot of con like I know it's not manufacturing but a lot of like construction storage that have like similar entailing workflows because it's all like the engineering like side of things but it's not doesn't have like the extra in between steps for like the manufacturing process. They usually love estimates and don't like opportunities.

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Method Junction: But for these guys, it's easier to manage because they have the purchase orders, they have the um sales orders, they have estimates, they have invoices,

and sometimes it's multiple because one chair to five chairs. Like that doesn't happen as much in like other industries where they're just like, "Hey, we have the one estimate, we have the one invoice, that's kind of all we really need sort of thing." Why Why is it Why is it like that though? Um because I know you mentioned most people will do the estimate. It's because um the way I talk about it because I I I I like opportunities but I think it's niche in the way that if you're like a simple construction company you have a customer you have a sub customer so you have a job and then from there's an estimate that you build and then from there it's invoice it's like always that same track the same process. So you don't need to manage the sales pipeline you just need to do your process sort of thing. But with them they have vendor list and options like looking through because they're really customized.

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Method Junction: So they have vendor list and options scope of work what they're looking for. They have to manage all the dates but also have to manage it in the PO sense while looking at the estimate date and all the design like everything they have to manage in a onehouse thing. So if you did in the estimates in this case it really doesn't make sense because with the estimate it's like estimate invoice. There's no managing of that process. It's just like once you it's like the estimate is the stage versus here it's like you have a bunch of different request because you can have five requests for quotes is what they use a lot which is a custom app which I'll get into next. Okay. And like from there if they have five requests for quotes and they make one estimate like if you did it through the estimate process it made five estimates. There was no way to like hold that information. So that's why they did it this way. Um, and then kind of like as you go through it like holds in all the material information and then the quote worksheet comparisons, um, kind of like what their productive profits are and it all holds based on the actual overall outcome of all the purchase orders, all the sales orders, what they actually invoice.

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Method Junction: So, and then they love to do all the reporting where they define a successful kind of opportunity as one that has a sales order. You know what I mean? So rather than it being the estimate or like the request, it's like their opportunities are the

managing actually the sales pipeline. So like that's the big difference where it's like you need a an app that's like not only project management but like just holding all the information stuff to view. That's what we like about opportunities. But then again where it's just like a simple there's step one, two, three of estimate, invoice, payment. What's the point of having an opportunity? It's literally just an extra step. And yes, it holds all the information, but if I have a button that says go to invoice, go to payment, where it's all logged on the estimate, it just kind of simplifies it in that way. So with them, you couldn't do it, but that's kind of the differences for some. I've I've noticed. Can you also remind me again, uh, what does SPK associates do?

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Method Junction: I know you mentioned they again, it's like the chair example is like a really good example. It's like they get requests for people to like manufacture like so many like a lot of different things. Yeah. And then like based on what they want um it could be like artwork, it could be um like different tapestries all like that type of stuff. Okay. Yeah. And then again they're like the mid mid ground to connect customers to their wholesalers. Okay. Okay. Yeah. Very interesting. Yeah. Um so I'd say opportunities is that the house that's where everything like lives pretty much. And then keep going to Bear with me. I'm not used to working on this keyword. Um, and then they got the request for codes. So, RFQS is a big thing for manufacturing because it's not the same. It's like is the same, which you'll notice, but it's not the same as an estimate. Okay? Because the biggest difference is not really like an overall like numeric amount.

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Method Junction: It's more like again like when you're looking at all this stuff, it's very much like these are the materials. this is the packing. It's like getting all the details they need for more of like the design process side of things rather than like actual pricing aspect which kind of comes in later based on if you need a chair we need to order four legs of seat in the back. It's like that idea. So it's like they get all their information here for like their potential request and then with their scope of work you can see like customer gave us this sample part with the specs. These are the specs. And then based on what they get here, you can see all the different like partitions, extra foam. I think this is I actually think this is might be a chair, funny enough. But um it gives them all the

materials so that once they have this here built, then from there, that's when they go into the actual item inside, but they don't even look at this item information until like they already did this.

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Method Junction: So could they have done this in estimate? like maybe I might have started there because again I didn't build this but when I talk about it with like Ryan who built it, it makes sense because they again they they go through this like top to bottom. So like they don't even get to like the actual item information till they get all that stuff from the client. And then once they get that stuff from the client, build it here and then from there they can go and actually um like create um different sales or what referencing and for requests for requests for quotes. These are quotes for the vendors or that they're getting requests from requests. It would be your SPK me saying, "Hey, I want a chair. This is all this is what I want in my chair. I want to look like this. This is a sample photo of what I want it to look like. Here you go." Then you can see like they have the convert to PO and then from there that's when it goes to the vendor

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Method Junction: go it goes to the vendor and then they go okay this is what we need this is the project we're looking to do. So it's like what they offer the customer is like hey we have a bunch of different wholesalers we're really good at manufacturing. if you tell us what we want you want, we can kind of give you that personalized flow and what they do for the vendors and saying, "You guys don't know how to get customers, let me get customers for you and connect you to ones that like fit your specific needs." So, like that's kind of like the two-sided relationship. Yeah. And then being able to store like all their PDFs here are going to be like different screenshots of um Oh, this one's the first order. Normally they're like uh Oh, so this one's like just pricing. But either way, sometimes they'll have like the actual sample and that's what's getting carried over um here and then that's again goes through the whole process for what's going in because again is it just packaging they need or maybe there's multiple purchase orders kind of connected to that.

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Method Junction: Is there um have they also added in things like pricing levels or pricing? So, no, because I think they just do a lot of like custom. It's like really depends. But with that being said, that is something I've recommended for them. Yeah. Because um what they do, so going back to again with the commission aspect, it's like they do tiers based off that. So then it's also like with what you're selling, you get paid more. So again, it's the same idea as that. So it's like based on certain products, it multipliers. So like yes, but they just didn't do it that way in the price levels where it's just they know which customers have which multipliers and then based on that they do the math themselves. Okay. Because sometimes you don't want to automate everything because they you got to check it. But like that's the big part of that. Um so opportunities kind of holding all like the managing the sales process side of things, the request from quote kind of getting that information from the customer of what they want quoted.

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Method Junction: Yeah. And then from there going into actually creating sales orders and creating purchase orders for what they need based on this is what the customer is requesting for the order. Again, same thing is kind of like the request for quote but like a tidier way to put it. And then this is what we need from these vendors are the separate purchase order. And then again separated kind of making sense. And then next step I feel like you're like testing me just because I literally had to do this for them. um is the quote worksheet. So again, this is ti each quote worksheet, think about it as like an estimate. This again, it's super custom. Um and each quote worksheet is going to be tied. So you can have multiple quote worksheets for requests for quotes. Again, I think this was more for like print templates. So you can like really specify which vendor and like again just a deeper dive into what they had with like all the packaging.

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Method Junction: So like you can put in for example like the overall for the request from quote and then you're like the first time they do it and then if there's any adjustments you multiple quote worksheets which would be like add addition orders or revisions but rather than it change with each one going from like one item two and then like two items

to three items it would be like three with one item. So it's like each one separated. Um, again, I don't really know why they did this one in particular, but we can all for like this case, we can ask. I can I can definitely like get you a better answer, but the biggest thing that they said is the quote worksheet is generated for the customer based on the return vendor pricing. So, there we go. So, yeah, once they get back from the c the vendor with the purchase order, they make this to say like this is your quote. Okay. So, this is what the estimate is. Okay. So, we uh the quote worksheet is more of like a finalized estimate that they're agreeing on.

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Method Junction: Yeah. So, request for quote that they pretty much broke down the estimate rather than an approval process was the request for quote and then the quote worksheet. Um and then from there, um yeah, they have this is more again for the designing side. So this would be probably more with what you're looking for again with the um same thing request being request approval being like the final and then the design breaking down and this is some of the descriptions you saw with like the instructions of what you're looking for like this is how these get built. So again when they're before they're filling out the quote worksheet or even after like for the request for quotes this is what they'll include meant like I want a chair with this like design rather than black like stuff like that. Mhm. Um, and then they have a lot of reminders and stuff to like follow up with vendors as well. I know it's like a weird way to like just bring it in, but like I find that they always say that their vendors are like the harder people to communicate with their customers.

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Method Junction: So, that's just like an obvious one. How did you guys manage um sending out purchase orders for multiple vendors? Um, so I think what it does is when they hit convert to purchase order, it does a distinct loop through all the vendors on that. So like loops through the list of the vendors that they've assigned for each thing. Exactly. Yeah. And then if like let's say there's five items, four vendors, it would be four different purchase orders, each one with one item, one with two because that's one. Yeah. So kind of like that. Okay. Um, but then again, I would say that one's really customer dependent because like I have other customers who um like do it with like a

preferred vendor and it might like change stuff or like want to select which ones they just want to create or they like put a drop down being like okay this purchase order is ready because again with the manufacturing process it's like you do it when it comes. So, like with that, it's like, hey, um, you're ready for right now to give me all the screws for that chair.

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Method Junction: Using that same example, but the wood's not going to be ready for two weeks. I still want the screws, right? So, it's like create the purchase order, make sure that's completed, but then have the other one created because sometimes they want to, especially with the inventory aspect with QuickBooks, that's just something to think about because um, invoices decreases it, sales orders decrease it, bills increase it. because it's like when you put it it come means you're coming it comes in for the vendor. So that's like the biggest thing where it's like even like some accounts um I have a medical manufacturing like place like GT simulators and what we do for that is we do like prepaid uh pretty much like sales orders and purchase orders where it's like a prepayment gets made so the inventory gets properly updated where you still have the purchase order there. So that's can be tracked and you can do all the changes. But then as you update what's been sent on the sales order, then that upper on the invoice or whatever it is that updates the purchase order item so that the amount stays the same.

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Method Junction: It's still paid on the invoice but that it keeps coming in to properly update the inventory. So that's really customer dependent on that because some people don't even use QuickBooks inventory. They just like it might like with them it's more like it comes in comes in and it goes out immediately. It's like nothing they have. It's like non inventory. So that's why they have the distinct list, but then it really depends on what they're tracking would be the biggest thing with that. Yeah. Um and then yeah, after that it's um just customer approving and once they approve, they build it and then invoice and then that that's it. And then invoices are just issued from the opportunity. You just have to create because it's all linked. So it just like summarizes all the sales order, summarize all the purchasers like you saw with the the bottom here like all this stuff, all the code worksheets, all that comparisons and then once they confirm it, it goes over.

And then um that's generally what like they did.

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Method Junction: Yep. And then what they've been working on now has been more like um reporting side of things mainly, but I don't really know if that helps you too much. Um Um uh oh, and then yeah, with like they have a the vendor portal is pretty cool. I can show you. Yeah, because the vendor portal is a different experience versus the customer portal because they're it's like it's the same thing as like us. They're like like they're part of their business still. Not like like a customer is always requesting, but it's like a more business relationship. So, it's obviously a little different. Um, yeah, because this one I I changed this and I did so I can speak a little bit better. I've done that way too many times. Uh, but is everything like any questions so far or is that like all making sense? No, that makes sense. Okay. Yeah, I said this to Nick as well. I worked in like wheat manufacturing like like three, four years ago.

00:19:11

Method Junction: So, if you have any like questions about that process or like not like that one in particular, but more like engineering side with all like the jobs and how that works, feel free to always ask. Yeah. I mean, um I I know from what I can tell SPK they're not handling their own shipping. So, they're outsourcing their shipping to someone else, I believe. So, as well. Yeah. Okay. Um, and are they handling um any like shipping tracking or saying that it's shipped from the RSI on that bid? They hold the tracking number. They just the tracking number. My understanding. Yeah. Okay. And is that tracking number using an API call or is just they just write? Okay. Yeah, I think they just put it in. Um, again the these guys are like this guy he to put into context this guy last night emailed me eight times because he did again it's like we we have a meeting today so that's what he does but he didn't understand how to make a new contact because when he put a field in if he didn't and it was like required and he goes to other one like he just gets lost.

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Method Junction: So it's like when it comes to customers like this always yeah for you guys like for how I think about it is there's certain stuff that just has to be manual to make like these people confident at the start and it's meant to be customized to be automated and then there's certain things where it's like you're doing a dumb task every time. Why like why the f*** like are you doing this? Yeah. So it's like to him that's how I propose like my click to it where it's like at the po at the first point I say okay let's start this where you're going to do press the button every time or you're going to input the tracking. Yeah. And then I'm just like you're going to tell me I'm telling you now we're going to talk about this in one month and you're going to tell me it's tedious but I want you to do it so you know how to add so that when we go to multiply it's easy. That's like the analogy. Um, but again once I think they get more comfortable, it's easier, but then at a start it's like do you have to have the option of what to automate versus what's good to be manual?

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Method Junction: Like that would be really cool probably for that for people because it's like the confidence aspect especially at the start when it comes to this stuff. Um, but yeah, with the portal, yeah, they have like they still get access to like pretty much all the dates and the scope of work and then there's also like a messaging board. So they like go back and they don't have to email anymore. They can just message here and it tracks it all. So like this is like a really cool thing. And then with the pallet details, they can go and like they have the amounts and update, but in terms of like the size for the shipping so that they know like what labels to get and everything like the uh vendor fills in that pallet information wait for them. So originally this was like a like a call or an email process that would go back and forth and had to be confirmed and stuff versus now it's like they hit this they hit save pallet details when they hit that sends an email to the people and then they have two options.

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Method Junction: They go uh accept deny the deny shoots back an email to customer or the vendor being like we need more details or whatever they fill in. this like this part I

would say like the vendor communication saves a lot of time because like people are wholesalers are like really busy most of the time because they're either doing the manufacturing distributing everything themselves and that's why his business exists to help them with that but because of that yeah this stuff I think saves them so many emails and then they'll even have like recurring activities that like send to the vendor like emails to the vendors just being like Hey, you haven't like updated us in a while. Like that type of stuff. So, it's like the constant communication with them. Yeah. I think is really key. Um because like once you lose a good wholesaler, like you that part of the business sort of thing, at least for them, not for everyone because like again going back to the GT simulators, which is the like medical grade manufacturing thing, like they got one wholesaler like they don't have they don't use vendors in or purchase.

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Method Junction: Like they literally have like again they do have vendors but in the sense of like more for particular things but most of the thing they're just like oh yeah we just got this in house put it together we're good. What's their process like? Um they're more of like the prepayment uh like they have a sales order. Yeah. Prepayment or like net30 kind of stuff. Whereas like customer requests like this is what we want. They just make the sales order. pay to pay now or whatever depending on the process and then like auto everything is managed pretty much from like the sales order on that one where it's like I don't even know I think yeah they go estimate that's where they put all the information in once they get the estimate accepted it goes to sales order and it's a prepayment the invoice the payment gets created with that one line that I was saying so if it's an $1,000 invoice it would just be one line that says prepayment $1,000 and as the four items go in the inventory updates and updates the invoice sort of thing.

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Method Junction: Um, and then with like the net30, that's for ones that are like international shipping because they ship all over the world. It's like medical stuff, right? So they'll like they ship to like Africa, they ship to weird parts in Asia because it's like all the like compression like dummies and like that type of stuff. Yeah. So like they're cool, but then again it's like they're just much more simple like simplified version of like that this type of stuff. Same thing with your question with like the vendors like they have a

create purchase order and it like splits up all the purchase orders for all the vendors that are on the preferred and then um what is it for the shipping they're also they wanted to do an API but um right now that's like where we're at right now we're probably going from the manual process to turning because they're using they're using QuickBooks custom fields for putting that in. So that's what we did to start, but that's kind of our next step. Are they handling anything about their pick packing um or packing slips with us?

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Method Junction: Um I don't know if they do packing slips to be honest. The only one that I have that does packing slips is CYC. And what they do is cool. They're like they're distributors. They're like thrift stores and stuff. So what they do is they have like freight orders, they have purchase orders, they have sales orders, proform invoice and just like normal estimates and they use packing slips and do all their own shipping. Is that like within nothing? Yeah. Well, they don't there's no like with like the shipping like information like they they still input but like I think they because they're still low low budget sort of thing but like there's so many like Ship Station SOS like I would say Ship Station is probably like the best one. We have so many accounts. Oh, okay. Ship. Yeah. If you like if you go because we have a catalog copy for that. So it's like we can just put that in. So if you like message Asher and Zach for example and you want like like one that has it already connected like if you say hey I need a good account that has shipstation who should I talk to like there's so many like the API like pre-connected tracking number goes it automatically and stuff I'm just not I haven't been there yet because like I'm just at the point where it's like that part's okay to be manual for now based on they're not ready for that.

00:26:19

Method Junction: Yeah. Yeah. Okay. Um yeah. So that is I would say kind of everything that I've done. Okay. For them and so any questions? Yeah. So um to me it sounds like the the workflow itself for the most part revolves around estimate sometimes maybe an estimate if not it'll go directly into a sales order or and you have that one I think I think that's valid. Estimate sales order purchase order invoice. And then are they also collecting payment through portal or are they doing something? Uh they collect payment through portal. Okay, sweet. All the three the two other accounts I said as well, the GT

Simcyc. Okay. And they're all handling shipment using the manual type in manual typing or using the API called sorry ship station. That one. Okay. And then is it sounds pretty like linear for the most part like they have a very linear problem. This is the most complex one I have.

00:27:20

Method Junction: this one. Yeah. Okay. Because they because again they wrote they don't use SMS. They request for quotes proposals. They have like a whole design process. They have to to manage vendors and they have to manage customers versus other people. It's just like we need these parts. You know what I mean? It's like not the same relationship. Yeah. Something else I'm also really curious about is um how many people are actually kind of a part of this process in terms of me working with them or in terms of them? Then let's get that answered together. I don't um so I work with Don mainly but there's three people who have been part of the process and this is like helpful for you guys too I think for when you want to know who's using what. Yeah. So the first place, so they have seven users, but with that being said, um it looks like Okay, so it looks like five to six of them are using it.

00:28:25

Method Junction: Yeah. Um and then let me the Oops. And then the other thing I like to check, so it's like I would say five people are probably doing it and then minus one because the main guy just does reporting. And then I like to the other place I like to look is here. Okay. Because if they have like a lot of sessions like January 28th a lot of sessions. So one this is done but I'll still call it two. Yeah. Three, four, and then like see he's a lot of sessions but hasn't been in a while. So I would say there's yeah five five to five to six people who are part of this process because I can tell if they have this many screens open like the 3,500 that means they're doing a lot. like opening a bunch of stuff. Even if like let's say like this guy who's like 731 June 28th like I would even say like I don't even know how much he does and like me looking at it.

00:29:17

Method Junction: Yeah. Like this guy this guy just does the outsourcing stuff. So it's like he's just working with shipping like I'm shipping is my guess based on this thing. So but that's like my point where it's like you can kind of figure it out based on that. Um but yeah, I would say five to six would be a good thing. If you want an exact number, I'm literally meeting with them in a little bit so I can talk. Yeah. I'd be curious about like um the different people behind the process. Like is our guy just dedicated to um like getting capturing all the requests stuff for all the sales, putting up the orders together? Is our guy focused on just the fulfillment process? I think they have they definitely have like with the commission side and then I'll tell you another thing we're doing right now which I think you'll find cool is um it's like very much like on the phone sales commission stuff and they are account managers too kind of so think about it like that where I think it's like onetoone like you manage the contact you manage the all the proposals that they have and then you like follow up like that's your job.

00:30:15

Method Junction: So I think it's more like that and it's a heavy like sales like role. Would the salespeople also be handling the invoicing or is that dedicated to someone else? Um, I'm gonna ask. Yeah, my guess would probably be um, no, but I'll I can I'll just ask it. So, if you have any little questions like that, I'll mark it down. Just ask because I'm just curious about the the people involved. Um, yeah, and their different and their different workflows like who's in charge of what. I know we got to see it holistically from like a bird's eye view of all the things that they're doing, but I'm sure they're dedicated to different people. This because this helps me anyway. Yeah. Um how roles are set up. are also their their vendors are shipping it out or are they is it coming to them and then they're uh again it depends if they have they manufacture still in house they do like manufacturing house but again depends what it is okay like chair versus a table they might do chair not do okay um yeah so the biggest thing that we're working on now which I think you're going to find cool is we're I'm working on a chat GBT integration with method through like Google Sheets and Zap.

00:31:40

Method Junction: So what it's going to look like is that pretty much again they have to f their first role job is like as a saleserson is they go and like get in all this information, put in all the opportunities, put in all their RFQS, request for codes, but it's really annoying for them because like they have to fill in very like they have to ask the exact same questions, put in the same thing. So they're pretty much like they ask all the questions and sometimes we'll be driving and doing this then they have to put it all into a spreadsheet and put it into method is how they work. Yeah. Um, but what we thought we were going to do now is you can import into chatbt an Excel file and be like this is your template and then and again we're still like we're still middle in the process but um what we what we he did is he said I'm going to have a chat conversation on the phone with chat GBT and then keep going back and forth where I'll like pause and then like say stuff to chatbt and then keep going.

00:32:31

Method Junction: and he could get it that he could fill out an an importable like opportunity Google sheet pretty much that has all the columns of it and then pretty much with chat GBT update a a shared like Google sheet and then there's a zap that says if a new line is created in the Google sheet do something in method so our thing is we're going to add the opportunity through that yeah so it's like a nice flow for him and again this is like specific but also helpful where it's like they just have to have a conversation. Yeah. With a person, not type in anything and just talk to chatbt. Yeah. And then say okay if it looks good or say what to fix and then immediately an opportunity to get screened. Yeah. Or like an opportunity activity or something. Such a game changer for them. Game changer for them because now a they don't have to repeat stuff three times. Yeah. Even though because like they were doing it I think like five times more.

00:33:24

Method Junction: And then the other thing is they don't have to type anything anymore. And it's also just like revolutionizing what then we can automate sort of thing for them. So it's like that type of stuff they're looking to do. Yeah. And um again I think the with

them in particular but I don't know if this is fair for all manufacturing like commissions is like a sales role too. Yeah. But like for example GT Sim there's like I don't think there's really any sales. They have a website they have Shopify and it like comes in like crazy. Okay. because they're just again it's just like the difference between hey I have these designs I want to manufacture versus hey I'm running a CPR course like I need dummies you know what I mean it's like a different type of request. Yeah. And then for the the medical line um do you know of the the people involved is it the same process? Is it there's someone who's I guess looking at the Shopify things that they're coming in and then Yeah.

00:34:23

Method Junction: So they have a technical pretty much like director. Okay. He's my point of contact. So we customize together. Like he's pretty good. Um so pretty much he we go on call, I do all like the harder stuff, he does the easy stuff and then he watches me do the harder stuff so he gets better. But he's the one who man like we together manage all the Shopify stuff that comes in because I bring I pretty much bring everything to his attention that's going wrong and he fixes it. So like addresses in Asia hate method as Oh yeah because there's like I think the postal codes are like 11 digits in some places. So it's like awful for us. So we had to like figure out something else because we can't use a state field or postal code field because we need a region and like a region code doesn't exist but again it's like niche. So it's like that type of stuff we like would manage and he does all that. And then I think the reps do everything like each rep is like sales.

00:35:20

Method Junction: But again, like I I I can pull up their flow too cuz I think like their their flow is super easy like compared to this one. And I can talk a little bit more on this guy because I built everything. Sorry, so many counts. Um Oh, did you want to order food and then eating things while you're talking? Yeah. That sucks. Did they bury you? your decision of paralysis on sushi. Yeah. Um I was looking at the salmon sushi. I just I'm going to be run to Avenue Open. I I just put my order through like an hour ago. Oh. Oh, damn. Okay. Okay. It's fine. I'll be back if that's okay. No, you're good. If anything, do you have more time later today? Do you want to continue? Or honestly, if you're okay, let me show you this really quick and if you have any other questions, you can let me know and

then I'll just go grab it.

00:37:45

Method Junction: Sweet. Um cuz this was this one's a lot easier. Um that's actually so annoying. Where's the So, wait, did did David order? Oh, he ordered already. Okay, he'll just pick up first. Okay. Do I want sashimi? No. No. Okay. Um, sweet. Okay, so this one's really easy. They go from an estimate, which is like super blank estimate, has some follow-ups to the customers. Yeah. Um, and then you can see like from here they can view their sales order. They can choose what payment methods go through and and pay for the products. You can see like by like how the screen looks like the top sticky, the bottom sticky like this is a full like Are they using estimates almost like um like a project folder where there's they can see everything? No, no, no. Estimates sales orders per everything's linked like when you create a like on the bottom here like after you hit create sales order this turns into view sales order.

00:39:15

Method Junction: Oh, okay. And then you also if you create multiple you can click here and view. And then once we get to the sales order you'll see like that's actually where the I would say like the magic is but this is like just the first step. Then they just go to a sales order again request for quote quote stuff. That's that to the sales order to like say what like the customer actually needs. You can see like ship method UPS again like this is what we were going to do a connection to UPS but they already had it in QuickBooks. we're remembering now. So, we didn't have to do that. And then yeah, like PO, GTO, PO remember. Then again, payments, purchase order, invoices, estimates. Click the estimate, it takes you there. Like everything's linked. And then like all the customer, they all of them have tags based on stuff. If it's over, they have one overdue stuff. Everything's managed through here. And then um we did a lot of HTML stuff.

00:40:07

Method Junction: So yellow is partially shipped, green is fulfilled, and then they're unfulfilled. So we know like this is a are they manually typing those are you manually

setting those statuses? So it depends. So if it's um if it's the prepayment with that prepayment imagine it's going to be an invoice with that one line that's going to be worth 2411 saying prepayment sales order amount. Yeah. Then all they have to do is they they'll go okay these two were shipped. So they type in two or three. Then what happens is on the sales like on the invoice rather than it just be the one line it will be two lines. One line that says prepayment sales order amount. One that says a quantity of two for this item and then for this rate and that prepayment sales order amount is whatever the two items at the rate is of this item minus the total. So it's still the total because the pay it can't change because that means it will cause conflict. Um, and then again, this is for like the item inventory update because they want the inventory to be live when they when it actually like ships out.

00:41:11

Method Junction: Yeah. Um, so that they know. Um, so that's how this one works. But if it's a net30 invoice, it updates me automatically. Okay. And sorry, go ahead. Yeah, go ahead. Um, I was just curious about the pack. Is that saying like, okay, yeah, I I like I picked the items and I packed them. Is that what the check mark is? the pack uh he added that I would I would assume. So that makes sense. Okay. Yeah. So Okay. Okay. Like it's packed and like it's packed and ready to go. So yeah. And then this way like that's why I'm saying the sales order is kind of like where the magic is because this is kind of like the project manager thing because you already have the invoiced part of it but now the invoiced will show yes they paid for it but it doesn't properly like know what progress it is. You know what I mean?

00:41:59

Method Junction: And then that was like a ticket I brought up to our team because how was I I still don't know if they fixed it yet to be honest, but how it was originally set up is you create a invoice and then that's what the invoice quantity was. It can't update. So if you change that amount or you invoice another one, it doesn't update. So I said to them it should be like the live current amount how that product is invoiced for the specific line item. So like you actually know what's invoiced and what's shipped. And then that's kind of why we did the ship column like this way for now because that wasn't set up. But my hope is that the invoice column gets updated live. Yeah. So as you create a sales order

and pick or create a purchase order, create an invoice for like the specific items or whatever that just updates immediately and rather than having to make a million invoices for it to like properly work, you can update the invoice.

00:42:48

Method Junction: And that's kind of the process that we set up for them. Yeah. Um biggest thing with this is partial shipping. got to think about that. It happens all the time where it's like when things are ready, that's you ship it. Like that's like think about Amazon. You order 10 things, they don't all come together. They're coming from different places. It's like that's the way you have to think about it. That would be the biggest thing. And then um it's being able to track the shipment like totals and what's been shipped, but also what's been paid for. So in the prepayment, again, all of it's been paid for. That's why the invoice column doesn't make sense. But with the net 30, they have to know when it's all items paid for if there's multiple in that sense. Um, so I think that's like the biggest thing with this one. And then yeah, they also use a packing slip. Do they handle um any back order, reordering, things like that that they would just add it to the sales order.

00:43:37

Method Junction: Okay. They would just add it to the sales order and then they'd be able to see the difference it with because they have the original estimate and that's what they refer to. Okay. Okay. And then um Okay. There's so many questions I wanted to ask. Oh yeah. Um, what app do you see yourself customizing a lot? Sales orders. Sales orders. Well, more more people again. This is like cuz it's like customer requesting stuff. Yeah. So, it's like they need a way to man it's like this is the how opportunities manages the pipeline instead of estimates like this manages all the shipments where we don't have a place to manage it. Okay. Okay. And then have you have it has anyone asked you for EDI? What's EDI? Um so EDI it's essentially um how you're sending sending invoices, purchase orders to a different um business and it's elect like it's all electronic. So instead of being an email PDF, it lives inside of almost like what I would we have that already like on the portal.

00:44:42

Method Junction: So, yeah, they were just you send it with it attached, but then they also can use the print button on the portal. Okay. Okay. Interesting. So, I know you got a few requests for EDI. Yeah. No, I don't I haven't got like I have three distributors. The other one asked me that. Okay. Yeah. Okay. Interesting. Yeah. These guys both of them just use like we just like how we set up the portal messaging like we have that too. So it's like that's like something I like to do a lot because I think it's you send it's f it's like slower than a text faster than an email sort of thing. Yeah. It's like in between. Yeah. So Okay. And and the other way it's like all logged. Yeah. Like not the same as like email would be. So that's usually how I do it. And then like with the everything on every email when they send it it attaches but then it's also available when they go to the portal for record.

00:45:32

Method Junction: So that's kind of enough for most of my customers. Okay. And then if there's one thing that you if you could wish upon a start that like we have a team of developers, you can build it out. This screen. This. Okay. No, no, no. Like this grid with how it's colored. Yeah. Do you know the amount of people that request coloring? Like like you you like not like the zebra coloring. I always say like I'd be honest. I'm like this is dumb. Like you don't need this because you can do it on it's only for internal, right? So if you want to do it on the report template, you can do that. But on this it's like all this is all HTML. Yeah, right. Like I we we do like we this is like this took us like like a year just like literally just the HTML stuff took us like six months, right? Like it it took us so long and I was with like like again just him being doing a lot of stuff as well, not just me.

00:46:21

Method Junction: Yeah. So I would say yeah like the shift I think is a big one. the invoice update like what I said to you with that ticket where it's like you can update an invoice you can update a sale like what what you said like what happens if there's a change and I said they just update the sales order it's like based on how we're currently laid out with no customizations that doesn't work yeah there's no real time and then and then the last thing is this screen purchase order but the like not not the purchase order the that's

okay um oh Okay. But with this screen, I get a lot of customization requests for this. And this is the so out of the box normally there's a vendor drop down here. There's no select or there is sorry a select but then you just do and you put it in like for ours like I changing the quantity is a big one. not for them. But then for these guys, they like let's say this would create one p one purchase order with this vendor.

00:47:24

Method Junction: If these were two different vendors, it would create two purchase or like that's custom. Like as of right now, you if you wanted to create two purchase orders with different vendors for this one, you'd have to go from the sales order, create purchase order, put the drop, select the items, create the purchase order, then you have to go back to the sales order, then hit the drop down, do the other vendor, select the items that you want. Okay. So is this the thing that I was asking about the multiple vendor for purchase and that's why I said like this is customized versus like day before they just have to like it like again like this let's say it took him like 20 15 minutes to like make two now it's like one button right it's just like limiting clicks for and like or giving like options for it's like are you like a one vendor thing or do you like because like if you take out that vendor drop down and make it even per line like that already like saves them time right and like loops through the distinct for that line.

00:48:17

Method Junction: Yeah. Um cuz like doing it the other and again it's a very personto person based like how they want but I think options here would be how how often are um how many of your accounts are using purchase orders for the or like from what I'm trying to ask is from the workflow perspective are they actually using purchase orders? I think four I'm I'm probably at four out of 22 that are using purchase orders. Okay. And they all I've customized like so this screen for everyone. Okay. like and it's always it's always something similar about either multiple wanting to do multiple vendors or like like having like the drop down to specify which vendor or just using the preferred vendor of the item and having it be distinct like that to create multiple. Okay. And the hard part with this screen how it's laid out is this this screen is is like you can see it's in the purchase order app even though we're in sales order. So if you're doing a creating a purchase order from estimate, invoice, sales order, anything it all goes to this screen.

00:49:26

Method Junction: So for like for this workflow to work, you only create purchase orders from sales orders. If you create from any other screen, it doesn't work. Just because that's how they laid it out. Yeah. But um like that's the other thing you guys have to like just note is that if you're going to do it with the same model of screen through when you go from different places, it does different like it has to do different things potentially, right? Or again, it's just like the option base being able to have a preference in purchase orders to say like how you want to create. I think that would be the big thing because it's really dependent on how they do it. Okay. And then the the like I guess the users involved is it still the same same person would be the same person. Okay. Um so it's just one like sorry this is the GT this is GT one one person does everything. One person does everything. So the so that they they don't have different people one person handling the shipment order.

00:50:17

Method Junction: Um but it is all a part of that one person's job to do the sales to do the shipment. It's like account management, not like Okay. Okay. For this one. Okay. And then for what the other account SVK, I have to ask. Okay. Yeah. I don't know. This one I just know because I did everything with them SVK. It's like this my second month. So I don't know. What about your um other N MW? So the other two, one's the CYC one. They're the thrift store and another one is Central Auction Group and they're kind of similar. they like are the the middle mid ground for auction auctioneers and like like selling it and getting it to auction. Um I think they're same. They're like one person does it all. They're campers. Okay. One person does it all. They do the the order fulfillment like the put inputting the order from the first time shipment. The only time it's multiple would be like SBK like you want me to like from my understanding I would say that's multiple people. Okay. just because again like when it's more complex and there's more like inhouse manufacturing like the other ones I'm saying they're mainly distributors it's like they don't really need to think about that like side of the business right so it's like they just get the full product from the vendor versus like SPK is getting materials okay right so that would be the difference I think with like the individual versus multiple okay for the account managers but those are still part of their responsibilities yeah probably

okay that would be my guess but again I can I'll confirm

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